How it started

Rooted Forward was started by Zain Zaidi, a student who lives on the Near South Side and goes to school in Hyde Park. Going between the two every day, he kept running into the bubble around the University of Chicago, and how completely the city changed from one block to the next.

He went looking for why, and found redlining, restrictive covenants, and the urban renewal campaigns that cleared and rearranged these blocks on purpose.

He ran a survey at the Obama Presidential Center and talked with more than 140 people about what they had lived through and what they had been taught. The gap was far wider than he expected, including among lifelong Chicagoans and especially among young people.

So he built this. Students in three cities do the archival work and run the outreach now, and what comes out of it gets published free.

We are active in Chicago, New York, and Washington, DC.

We could use your help

If you can dig through an archive, run a survey table at a market, or edit audio, there is work here for you. You do not need experience to start.

rooted-forward.org

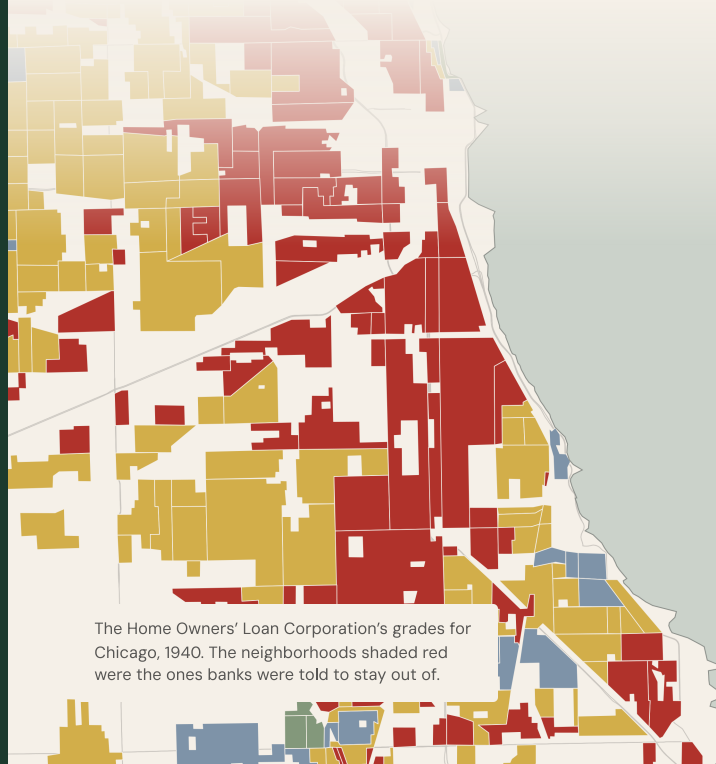
contact@rooted-forward.org

Rooted Forward

Cover map drawn from Home Owners' Loan Corporation records, 1940, by way of Mapping Inequality, University of Richmond. Streets and shoreline on both maps from U.S. Census TIGER/Line.

Rooted Forward

A student-run nonprofit started in Chicago. Rooted Forward educates people about racial inequality in cities across the United States, and works to address it through education, awareness, and political advocacy.



The Home Owners' Loan Corporation's grades for Chicago, 1940. The neighborhoods shaded red were the ones banks were told to stay out of.

Ways we help

Self-guided walking tours

Students research one neighborhood at a time and build a tour out of what they find. It lives on the Rooted Forward app, free to walk or to read at home.

Community outreach

We set up where people already are, like the Obama Presidential Center and neighborhood markets, and we survey and interview residents about their own block.

The podcast

We record long conversations with people who have lived through what we research, and those conversations decide what we work on next.

Policy advocacy

We run petitions on Chicago bills that are already introduced and stuck in a committee, then hand the signatures to that committee.



Walk Hyde Park

Stops
13, plus 3 detours

On foot
About 4 miles

Audio
About 70 minutes

Price
Free

HALF MILE

The tour goes through the Chicago neighborhood of Hyde Park, stopping at sites that reflect its deep racial history and the inequality that still shapes the neighborhood today. It starts at Paul Cornell's stone by 53rd Street and ends at Harper Court.

Free in the **Rooted Forward** app for iPhone, or in any browser at **rooted-forward.org/tours**.

1. Paul Cornell's stone
2. The Del Prado
3. The tracks and Lake Park
4. The White City
5. The Obama Center
6. The first Del Prado
7. The Midway line
8. Rockefeller Chapel
9. The Robie House
10. The University of Chicago
11. Stagg Field and the pile
12. The Hansberry house
13. Daley's Restaurant
14. Drexel Boulevard
15. Fifty-Fifth Street
16. Harper Court

Stops 12, 13 and 14 are optional detours.

An Illustrated Map of Chicago



The map and its touch screen on the museum's wall in Bridgeport, September 2026. Photograph by Rooted Forward.

Rooted Forward and the Chicago Maritime Museum created this exhibit to explore the history behind a 1931 illustrated map of Chicago. Visit the museum in Bridgeport to see the map and explore it on the touchscreen beside it.

Chicago Maritime Museum
1200 West 35th Street, Chicago